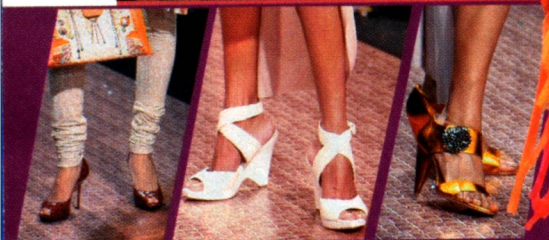


STYLE ASIDES

SARANG SENNA

In the absence of any high profile international buyers, it was the eccentrically-dressed who outshone the rest. This year Yu Masui (left), freelance fashion consultant for Japan's leading store Isetan, stood out in the front row. He wore everything from pirate hats to orange PVC shorts.



Tahiliani's line was accessorised by a shoe-line by a 30-year-old Italian label from Fermo, Giorgio Fabiani. Fabiani made a personal appearance, keen to break into the Indian market. "People here will accept and understand the product," says the stylist.

The other newbies failed to impress.

It was left to the old guard to rise to the occasion and save the day. Rajesh Pratap's opening show was a hit, thanks to tunic dresses with Peter Pan collars, Dolman sleeves and honeycomb prints. Designer duo Shantanu & Nikhil followed it up with a Banarasi tale of regeneration coupled with texturised fabrics and block-prints interpreted in their inimitable style. Day two was salvaged by Tahiliani and Monisha Jaising. While Tahiliani travelled from Kutch to Kenya, Jaising took her seductive classicism a notch higher. As Abhishek Gupta and Nandita Basu's label Fightercock paid homage to the

TRIBAL TOUCH: A creation by Tahiliani



country with Cent Percent Indian, an original and utterly individualistic line, Varun Bahl proved his couture consistency with his collection 'Unpredictable: A Tribute for Essenza Di Wills'. Besides his shifting silhouettes in unforgettable hues of green, smoky blue and muddy yellow, the one lasting image of the fashion week will be that of his models dressed in black, wearing hats—a fitting tribute to the late Isabella Blow.

As the designer doffed his hat at fashion's "nutty aunty", the stalls saw a slow burn and the buyers' buzz was distinctly low-key. Of the long list of registered international buyers, only a handful were seen sniffing around the stalls. With much-touted names like Maria Luisa (Paris) and Villa Moda missing in action, it was Home Store (Turkey), Moda In (Kuwait) and Indiva (Toronto) who were reeling the designers in. While Armand Hadida from L'Eclaireur, Paris, said designers were rolling out collections without a clear eye on target markets, domestic buyers were busy tallying up orders. "There is such a huge potential in the domestic market, but we are still after foreign buyers," lamented designer Namrata Joshipura. But desi buyers like Pradip Hirani of Kimaya are not complaining. "Indian buyers are responsible for almost 97 per cent of the trade. For us, it is business as usual," he says.

As WIFW standing shoulder-to-shoulder with the Delhi Book Fair at Pragati Maidan, it's safe to conclude that the EXCI's move to this venue might not have been fashionable enough but it sure was a practical one. A compact venue tailor-made for trade might just be what EXCI chief Rathi Vinay Jha needs to get rid of the tamasha tag. But not all is right with Indian fashion yet. Largely, spring-summer looked dull and even as the red carpet was rolled up, one wondered if a handful of decent shows could make-up for the otherwise lacklustre week. ■



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